keeping with that pursuit of excellence, the Best Colleges survey has constantly tried to become better. Over the years, it has become evident that institutions with deep historical roots, many with outstanding faculty, cutting-edge infrastructure and a legacy of attracting top students, tend to dominate the top slots. While such performance is undoubtedly deserved, it risks overshadowing smaller or newer institutions that are making impressive strides.

To make amends for this, this year's edition introduces a new category: India's Most Improved Colleges. Across 14 streams—Arts, Science, Commerce, Medical, Dental, Engineering, Architecture, Law, Mass Communication, Hotel Management, BBA, BCA, Social Work and Fashion Design—we spotlight one college in each stream that has shown the greatest improvement in scores and rankings over the past five years (read methodology). This isn't just a tweak in rankings; it's a recognition of grit, reinvention and upward momentum.

The purpose of this initiative is twofold. First, it encourages healthy competition among colleges that may not have had a head start but have been working hard at closing the gap. Second, it expands the horizons of options for students and parents. Not making it into the so-called 'top' colleges is no longer a setback. There are now several emerging centres of excellence that offer a comparable, if not superior, educational experience. And that college may not necessarily be in a big city. For employers, this opens up new recruitment pools where raw, trainable talent is being put through the paces.

This new segment also seeks to address the long-standing regional imbalance in Indian higher education. Building a world-class system isn't only about expanding capacity. It's about ensuring equity and access across geographies. Today, a disproportionate number of top institutions are clustered in a handful of states. Bridging this regional divide requires deliberate and sustained effort. Our rankings reflect that: they go beyond metros to showcase promising institutions in Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities, many of which have climbed into the top 30. Quality, it seems, is finally allowing itself to be democratised.

The 2025 survey, as earlier, lists the top three colleges in each of several smaller cities, making this the most inclusive and granular assessment of India's higher education ecosystem. Unsurprisingly, the number of participating colleges has surged—from 988 in 2018 to 1,865 this year. Educators have credited this to the sparking of a competitive spirit even among remote institutions, offering them a tangible incentive to raise the bar.

These value additions align seamlessly with the founding philosophy of the India Today Best Colleges Survey: to highlight good practices, recognise excellence and capture emerging trends before they become mainstream. At the heart of this endeavour are those who matter the most—students and educators.

Over time, the survey has added several innovations to reflect the real-world choices students face. While institutional prestige matters, what students increasingly look for is

EMERGING COLLEGE HUBS

Cities whose colleges figure in the top 30 for each stream

STREAM	CITY	NO. OF COLLEGES
ARCHITECTURE	LUCKNOW	2
ARTS	PATNA	1
BBA	PUNE	1
BCA	COIMBATORE	2
COMMERCE	CHANDIGARH	1
DENTAL	MANGALURU	2
ENGINEERING	PUNE	2
FASHION DESIGN	KOLKATA	3
HOTEL MANAGEMENT	PUNE	3
LAW	PUNE	3
MASS COMMUNICATION	PUNE	2
MEDICAL	PUDUCHERRY	1
SCIENCE	CHANDIGARH	1
SOCIAL WORK	COIMBATORE	4

#9

India's global rank in terms of citations generated by research papers

0.6-0.7%

What India spends as percentage of GDP on research and development; global average: 1.8%